

THE UHRMACHER'S FOLLY

DM Adventure Guide

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TABLE CONVENTIONS

- **Initiative:** PCs roll individually; each encounter's creatures roll as one group (stirges / Fritz + golem / modrons). The **environment acts on initiative 20**, lair-style — in Act III the cuckoo itself is part of the machine turn.
- **Battle maps:** the tower's front (front door, clock face, planar aperture) is the **bottom edge** of every map; players approach from the bottom.
- **Timeline:** Wilhelm's era is 1742; the present day is 1804 — the tower stood dead for some sixty years.
- **Map sets:** print map + DM guide per combat room; Cuckoo's Landing adds the platform overlay sheet and the set-on-top rod piece.

THE GASTHAUS

Act I • Social • Freudenfeld

READ-ALoud

The Gasthaus is low-ceilinged and wood-paneled, warm from a Kachelofen in the corner. Long communal tables fill the room, and the air smells of bread and beer. A few locals nurse drinks in the late afternoon light. An old man in a wood-cutter's coat is holding court in the corner near the stove, mid-story, gesturing with his pipe. A woman sits alone at a side table with an untouched drink, staring at nothing in particular. A well-dressed man wearing a mayoral chain sits at a table at the back and waves you over with a broad smile.

NPCs AT A GLANCE

Bürgermeister Grüber (*Stammtisch, stays seated*) — Loud, warm, charismatic. Calls you over, claps your back.

Frau Eichenwald (*alone, side table*) — Composed but visibly troubled. Stayed later than usual. Won't approach.

Heinrich (*corner, near stove*) — Chatty, storyteller's cadence, pipe and tankard. Mid-story.

BÜRGERMEISTER GOTTFRIED GRÜBER

First Impression (at his table)

Up close he is enormous — broad, well-fed, filling his whole end of the table — but the face wins: bright, beaming, genuinely delighted to see you. The mayoral chain is polished to a shine. His eyes keep working the room even while he grips your hand.

Will Share

- Job: clear vermin from a structure in the Tiefenwald
- Pay: 25gp per head, on completion
- Directions to the tower, lodging for the night
- The "Tickwichtel" are back and the town is thriving

Doesn't Know

- What the modrons actually are
- What the tower does long-term
- The contract or the Uhrmacher's history

Key Line

"The town has never been better. We just need someone to clear out the pests so the little folk can finish their work."

FRAU EICHENWALD

First Impression

She sits very straight even alone — a teacher's posture. Proud, a little gaunt, dressed with careful modesty. The drink in front of her is untouched, and up close you can see she isn't tired: she is working on a problem she cannot solve.

Will Share (if approached)

- Her students are losing curiosity and imagination — stories bland, pictures prosaic, no silly outbursts
- She blames the Tickwichtel — believes the legend that they murdered the Uhrmacher, and now they're "poisoning" the children
- Fritz has stopped attending class — she doesn't know where he's gone
- She's tried talking to parents but they see nothing wrong with "good behaviour"

Key Line

"The children are so well-behaved now. I should be grateful. So why does it frighten me?"

HEINRICH

First Impression

Sinewy and hunched from a lifetime of axe-work, with huge calloused hands wrapped around his tankard — and the kindest old smile in the room. He is mid-story before you've finished sitting down.

Will Share (loves to talk)

- Saw a Tickwichtel in the woods as a boy of seven — it barely noticed him, but the memory shaped his life
- Excited they're back — he's a celebrity again, people care about his stories
- But also carries unease from childhood: things "weren't right" back then, and something tragic happened
- Believes the Uhrmacher froze himself in time when the ticking stopped

Unreliable Details

Thinks the Tickwichtel gave the Uhrmacher magical powers and could control time. Emotional truth is there; facts are not.

Key Line

"I was six, maybe seven. It was no bigger than my hand, all brass and little legs, clicking away. It didn't even look at me."

SECRETS

- Back room available for private party discussion
- Eichenwald will **not** approach — players must go to her

-
- Heinrich's stories are colourful but unreliable — the emotional truth is real, the details are wrong
 - Grüber's eyes are always scanning the room — he observes more than he lets on

TRANSITION

Party heads to the Kuckucksuhrturn. Grüber gives directions: a path into the Tiefenwald, about an hour's walk. Tower visible above the treeline.

THE CLOCKHALL

Act II • Social • Kuckucksuhrturn — Ground

READ-ALoud — APPROACH

The path into the Tiefenwald narrows quickly. The canopy closes overhead and the light goes grey-green. It is quiet — not silent, but ordered. You notice that the trees along the path stand at strangely even intervals, and the birdsong overhead has a pulse to it, almost a rhythm, as though the forest were keeping time to something you can't quite hear. After an hour's walk, the trees thin and the tower comes into view: tall and narrow, built of dark timber, with a steep shingled roof and carved eaves like an enormous cuckoo clock standing alone in a clearing. You can hear it ticking from here.

READ-ALoud — ENTERING

The front door opens onto the remains of a life: a cold hearth, a narrow cot, a workbench drowned in tools and paper — all of it pushed to the walls, because the center of the room belongs to the clock. The mechanism's spine runs floor to ceiling, brass wheels within wheels, shafts climbing into the dark above, and every part of it is turning. Small brass spheres flit and scurry through the works on fan-shaped wings, scrubbing moss and pale fungus out of the gear teeth. Among them stands a bronze cube on two short legs, wings folded at its back, holding a clipboard, watching you with recessed eyes. It speaks in a voice that is almost, but not quite, monotone: "You are the exterminators. Yes. Good. That is — we expected you sooner. It is fine."

NPCs AT A GLANCE

Pendel (among the gears, clipboard in hand) — Overwhelmed, frenetic, hedging. Not quite the authority he's supposed to be.

PENDEL

On a Closer Look

The bronze is old and weathered. A hairline crack runs down one side of its body, and growing out of the crack — unmistakably — is a small green weed. Pendel does not appear to know it is there.

Will Share Freely

- The job: clear the bellows upstairs, recover the Gear
- Directions upstairs, and that the Gear must be installed below

Will Share if Asked

- The tower is being restored under a contract
- The "small folk" are from another place
- Basic facts about Mechanus

Doesn't Think to Share

The consequences of activation, or why the Uhrmacher disconnected. Not relevant to Pendel.

Rogue Tendencies

Slight hesitations. A name it chose for itself. A tiny weed growing from a crack in its body. Players who notice and engage get a confused, almost emotional response.

Key Line

"The bellows are... infested. We are not equipped for biological interference. You are. Please proceed upstairs."

SECRETS

- Hidden door in the wood paneling leads to the Uhrmacher's Study (DC 14 Investigation, DC 12 if specifically searching the walls)
- Trapdoor/stairs down to the Winding Room — visible, but Pendel directs them upstairs first
- Pendel's weed and self-chosen name are signs of going rogue
- The moss and fungus the monodrones are cleaning out is Linde's sabotage — players won't know this until they meet her
- **Back window:** Players who scout the exterior before entering can spot a window on the back of the tower — leads directly into the Uhrmacher's Study, bypassing the Clockhall entirely

ARTIFACT — LETTER FROM KOHLER

On the workbench, partially buried under modron work orders — which is why it's still here. A warm, teasing letter

TO the Uhrmacher from his old friend Kohler (dated 1742), replying to Wilhelm's proud reports: the town thriving, the tower keeping perfect time. Kohler affectionately waves away Wilhelm's first small worry (the woodcarver's identical chairs). No doubt anywhere — the players don't hear Wilhelm's own voice until the journal. Typeset prop.

CONNECTIONS

- **Outside:** Front door (Tiefenwald path)
- **Up:** Staircase to the Bellows Chamber
- **Down:** Stairs/trapdoor to the Winding Room
- **Side:** Hidden door to the Uhrmacher's Study

TRANSITION

Pendel directs the party upstairs to clear the bellows. Players may also explore the room, find the letter, discover the hidden door, or go down to the Winding Room on their own.

THE BELLWS CHAMBER

Act II • Combat • Kuckucksuhrtrurm — Upper

READ-ALoud

The staircase opens into a wide chamber dominated by two enormous wooden bellows, one on each side, like the lungs of some massive creature. Brass pipes run from the tops of the bellows up through the ceiling. The far wall is the back of the great clock face itself — a full storey of dark banded wood, the hands' axle driving through it in a slow and tireless turn, an old workbench pushed up against it. The bellows are choked with debris, dried nesting material, and something else — movement. Small dark shapes cling to the pipes and rafters overhead. Then they notice you.

SECRETS

- Both ducts have uncapped service stubs (west F3, east F10; Perception DC 15, or spot the fallen caps on the floor nearby) — the stirges moved into the duct system through them
- The two swarms nest IN THE PIPES: working a bellows blasts its duct and flushes a swarm out of that side's stub. Restoring the air = work both bellows + re-cap both stubs
- The Gear (Cross-Planar Regulation Gear, contract §1.2) is re-packed in its original modron shipping crate (I4) — the Uhrmacher boxed it when he disconnected it
- The delivery manifest lies on the workbench (I8–I9) against the front wall — the back of the great clock face, its motion works protruding beside the bench. The manifest matches the crate

ARTIFACT — DELIVERY MANIFEST

On the workbench, among the tools. The original packing manifest from the Modron Collective (contract Art. II §2.1): modron bureaucratic language, Mechanus serial numbers, planar specifications — first concrete evidence the tower is connected to another plane. References an installation manual (enough to install the Gear without Pendel). Wilhelm's handwritten margin notes. Typeset prop.

CONNECTIONS

- **Down:** Staircase to the Clockhall
- **Up:** Ladder at H5, beside the main air riser, right behind the clock face — emerges at the landing hatch above

TRANSITION

Party clears the bellows, recovers the Gear. Return downstairs through the Clockhall to install it in the Winding Room below. Second pass through the Clockhall — another chance to talk to Pendel, notice the hidden door.

ENCOUNTER

See next page.

ENCOUNTER — BELLOWS CHAMBER

Act II • Combat • Hard / ~2,100 adj. XP

STIRGE (X6) — CR 1/8

AC	HP	Speed	Atk	Dmg
13	5	10/fly 40	+5	6 (1d6+3)

Attach: While attached, cannot attack. Target takes 5 (2d4) necrotic at start of stirge's turn. Any creature within 5 ft can use an action to detach it.

SWARM OF STIRGES (X2) — CR 2

AC	HP	Speed	Atk	Dmg
14	36	10/fly 40	+5	14 (2d10+3)

Resist: Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing

Immune: Charmed, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Prone, Restrained, Stunned

Swarm: Can occupy another creature's space and move through any Tiny opening.

Grapple: Medium or smaller targets in the swarm's space are grappled (escape DC 13). Grappled targets take 7 (2d6) necrotic at end of their turn.

Bloodied: Damage drops to 8 (1d10+3).

WAVES

Trigger	Enemies
On entry	6 stirges (perched on the overhead ducts)
First bellows worked (action)	1 swarm flushed out that duct's stub (west F3 / east F10)
Second bellows worked	The second swarm, out the other stub

The stubs (key mechanic): each duct has an uncapped service stub (F3 west, F10 east; fallen caps on the floor beside them). The swarms nest in the pipes — working a bellows is how the party flushes them: *they control when the swarms come*. Restore the air channels: work BOTH bellows + re-cap BOTH stubs.

ENVIRONMENT

- **Two bellows** (east/west walls, 2×4 each) — impassable, climbable, half cover behind
- **Overhead ducts** (dashed on the map) — run from each bellows to the central manifold (G/H-4/5 corner); main riser climbs behind the clock face
- **Workbench** (I8-I9, manifest) and **modron crate** (I4, the Gear inside) on the front wall; clock-face motion works at I6-I7
- **Junk field** — all 41 hatched squares on the DM guide are difficult terrain

END CONDITION

All stirges dead or driven off. Both bellows worked + both stubs re-capped — the air channels are restored (enables the cuckoo's Call in Act III).

INITIATIVE

One roll for all stirges; environment acts on initiative 20.

DM NOTES

- Individual stirges go down in one hit — let players feel effective early
- Swarms are the real threat: B/P/S resistance means martial damage is halved, grapple + necrotic drain is dangerous
- Casters with AoE or magic damage shine against the swarms
- If too easy: a few surviving stirges re-emerge from crevices
- If too hard: a swarm at half HP scatters and flees up the pipes
- Map set: bellows_chamber_map (print) / bellows_chamber_guide (DM)

THE WINDING ROOM

Act II • Combat / Social • Kuckucksuhrturn — Below

READ-ALoud

Stone steps descend into a long vaulted chamber, and the tower's heartbeat is suddenly all around you. Heavy iron and brass gear trains wall off the dark in every direction; the only ways forward are three narrow service lanes threading between the machines. Chains hang from the ceiling gloom, and shapes the size of oxcarts hang with them — colossal cast-iron pinecones, some lowered to the floor where they sit blocking the lanes outright. Somewhere deeper in the works, something heavy shifts its weight.

The cradle, the camp, and the golem are not visible from the entrance — the maze reveals them. The golem is caged in the mid-band until the first effective chain pull; the camp is in Fritz's walled-off corner.

NPCs AT A GLANCE

Fritz (his walled-off corner home (A7–B8)) — Defiant first, not scared. Fiercely independent. Waiting for respect.

Gear Golem (caged in the mid-band (G8), released by the first effective chain pull) — Hostile — attacks on Fritz's standing orders.

When Fritz Is Found (Perception DC 12)

Wedged behind the machinery is a boy — eleven, maybe, scrappy and thin, dirty from living rough, in patched clothes a size too big. He doesn't flinch and he doesn't run. Under the messy dark hair, a pair of bright eyes glares out at you with pure defiance: whatever you're here for, the look says, he was here first.

When the Golem Is Released

The counterweights shift somewhere in the dark, and something answers them — footsteps, heavy enough to feel through the floor. Out of the machinery steps a figure of interlocking brass cogs and clock springs, eight feet of it, amber light burning where eyes should be. It does not roar. It walks, patient as a pendulum, and puts itself between you and the deeper room.

FRITZ

Will Share if Calmed

- He's been living here since his leg started working again
- The tower makes him better — his leg was useless before
- The golem protects him
- He doesn't want anyone to take the tower from him
- The journal — he'll show it (or hand it over) once treated with respect

Doesn't Know

What the Gear does, what the modrons are planning, the contract, the long-term consequences — the journal's warnings went over his head.

Key Line

"I could barely walk before. Now I can run. You're not taking that from me."

SECRETS

- Fritz is hiding — Perception DC 12 to spot him behind the machinery
- Fritz controls the golem with a brass winding key he found — taking it is possible but feels like a betrayal
- Fritz doesn't know the Gear needs to be installed here — players can persuade him (Persuasion DC 12) or deceive him. Treat him as an equal; patronising him makes him dig in.
- If players tell Fritz they want to harm the tower, the golem fights to the death
- The discarded leg brace lies by the east approach (near C8, outside his corner) — tells the story before the players meet him
- Fritz has the Uhrmacher's journal — he found it in the works and has tried to read it, but he can't read well and hasn't fully understood it

ARTIFACT — THE UHRMACHER'S JOURNAL

In Fritz's camp — a roleplay reward, not a floor pickup: earn his trust and he shares it; fight past him and they may never see it. Later entries in a shaking hand: the Uhrmacher has noticed the changes — conformity, loss of individuality. Regret. Mentions disconnecting the Gear. Opposite tone from Kohler's optimistic letter in the Clockhall. Type-set prop (journal-disconnection; DM pocket piece journal-something-wrong).

CONNECTIONS

- **Up:** Stairs to the Clockhall

THE INSTALLATION

Play it as a triumph that feels wonderful and is terrible.

The seating (as they work)

The Gear is heavier than anything its size has a right to be. It settles into the cradle like it was poured there, and the clamps close over its rim on their own — four soft clicks, like a door being locked politely. For a moment, nothing. Then the small idle gears beside the cradle lean in and mesh, and the tower's drive takes up the Gear's weight. It begins to turn — one slow, enormous revolution, dragging the whole room's machinery with it.

The snap

You've been hearing the tower's tick for hours — you'd stopped noticing it. You notice it now, because mid-swing, it corrects. Not gradually. Between one tick and the next, every wheel in the building shivers into phase, a thousand slightly-staggered beats collapsing into one. TICK. The silence between the beats goes absolute — no rattle, no chatter, no mechanical slop anywhere in the tower. Just the beat, and the waiting. Somewhere under the floor, something begins to hum in perfect fifths with the ticking. Your own heartbeat feels suddenly unpunctual.

Follow-on beats

- Candle flames burn straight up; dust settles into faint parallel ridges; everyone exhaled at the same moment
- **Jump the conformity escalation a full beat immediately.** The manifest's fine print already disclaimed effects "in the vicinity of the Gear" — if a player rereads it here,

reward the horror

- Pendel, if present: visible, profound *relief* — the first genuinely emotional thing the party sees a modron do
- The one line to keep: **nothing sounds broken anymore — and that's the most frightening sound the tower has made yet**

TRANSITION

The Gear is installed; the Activation Sequence has begun. The tower is in perfect time and the connection is completing. Players need to get to the apex.

ENCOUNTER

See next page.

ENCOUNTER — WINDING ROOM

Act II • Combat / Social • Hard by geometry / Golem CR 5

GEAR GOLEM (FLESH GOLEM) — CR 5

AC	HP	Speed	Atk	Dmg	Save
9	127	30 ft	+7 (x2)	13 (2d8+4) + 4 (1d8) ltn.	—

Start position: G8 (east mid-band) — caged behind the counterweights, released by the first effective chain pull

Immune: Lightning, Poison; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned

Aversion to Fire: Fire damage → disadvantage on attacks/checks until end of next turn

Berserk: When bloodied, roll 1d6 at start of its turn; on a 6 it goes berserk — ignores Fritz's commands and attacks the nearest creature, *including Fritz*. Only Fritz can end it: reach the golem, spend his turn at it with the brass key — it calms on his next command, automatically. The rescue-the-boy beat.

Lightning Absorption: Regains HP equal to lightning damage taken

Magic Resistance: Advantage on saves vs. spells

Immutable Form: Can't be shapeshifted

SOCIAL RESOLUTION

Approach	DC
Find Fritz	Perception 12
Persuade Fritz (help the tower)	Persuasion 12 — true, and he wants that
Deceive Fritz	Deception 14 — his skepticism is his armor
Intimidate Fritz	Auto-success, no roll — but the golem reads his fear as a threat and goes berserk immediately. A trap option.
Calm golem directly	Not possible — only Fritz (or holding his brass key) commands it

Fritz calls off golem: It stops immediately and stands down. Fritz watches warily but lets the party work.

Fritz learns they want to harm the tower: Golem fights to the death. Fritz hides and won't call it off.

Golem goes berserk: It stops obeying and attacks the nearest creature — including Fritz. If Fritz is hiding, someone has to get the terrified boy to his rampaging protector.

THE MAZE — PINECONES & CHAINS

- **Room:** 9×14 squares; three single-file lanes through dense machinery; crossings at K3–K4 and G6–G7. No ranged sightlines except along open lanes.
- **Mounting cradle** in the 4×3 backroom (cols 2–5), centered on the A/B–3/4 intersection; **Fritz's camp** is the walled-off 2×2 nook at A7–B8
- **Four colossal cast-iron pinecone counterweights** (3×3 each) hang at two levels (rows E and I); each drops at its outer lane or the shared middle — a pinecone cannot drop where another sits. Each level always has exactly one lane open.
- **Eight pull-chains**, never beside their own pinecone. Pulling costs an **action**; impossible moves grind or jam audibly. Tracing a chain to its pinecone: action + easy Investigation.
- **Caught under a descending pinecone:** DC 14 DEX save, dive to an adjacent open square; fail = 7 (2d6) bludgeoning + prone
- **The golem never damages machinery** — blocked lanes genuinely stop it. Anyone can pull chains: players, Fritz, the golem.

Chain	Pulls	Effect
G2	LW→west	opens lower mid — first effective pull: traps the puller, releases the golem
G6	LW→mid	the re-arm chain, beside the golem's cage
M3	LE→mid	opens lower east
K2	LE→east	opens lower middle
B4	UW→mid	backroom endgame control
C3	UW→west	backroom endgame control
L2	UE→mid	opens upper east
C8	UE→east	opens upper middle, seals the puller in Fritz's corner — Fritz can pull it himself: the social path's pay-off

Start: sealed — upper level open east, lower open west, no route through. Minimum two pulls to any route (G2 → C8). The “west parade” victory exists: both levels open west, party walks past the caged golem. Full layout: `scenes/encounter-04-winding-room.md` + DM guide map.

END CONDITIONS

1. **Golem defeated** — Fritz is terrified, may flee or surrender
2. **Fritz calls off golem** — social resolution, golem stands down
3. **Gear installed** — clicks into the mounting cradle regardless of how Fritz/golem were handled

INITIATIVE

One roll for Fritz + the golem (they act together); environment acts on initiative 20 (machinery beats, e.g. a counter-weight groaning down after a pull).

FRITZ AFTERWARD

Depends on the party: befriended, he trails them up and watches Act III from the landing hatch; frightened or fought, he hides below with the golem and is found in the epilogue. **Killing the golem:** no notated consequence — play Fritz's reaction in the moment; it is a child's only protector.

DM NOTES

- On paper the golem is Easy for 7 level-3 PCs — the map is the difficulty: single-file lanes limit engagement to 1–2 PCs while it deals ~34 avg per round (17 per slam — can down a level-3 PC in one round)
- AC 9 means players almost never miss — encounter is HP attrition
- Magic Resistance and immunities shut down some caster strategies; fire is the key weakness (disadvantage on everything)
- Players not facing the golem work the maze: tracing chains, relaying positions, climbing through the works
- Multiple valid solutions (fight, talk, sneak) — pure combat is the least interesting path
- Map set: `winding_room_map` (print),
`winding_room_guide` (DM)

THE UHRMACHER'S STUDY

Act II • Social / Discovery • Kuckucksuhrturn — Ground (hidden)

READ-ALoud — VIA HIDDEN DOOR

The paneling swings inward to reveal a small room thick with dust. A writing desk cluttered with papers and an inkwell sits beneath bookshelves crammed with leather-bound volumes. Clock diagrams are pinned to the walls. Everything is untouched — cobwebs connect the chair to the desk. Someone left this room and never came back. And squatting on the desk — ignoring the chair entirely — is a young woman who absolutely does not belong here. Barefoot, twigs in her hair. She looks up with sharp, curious eyes. “And what are you here for?”

READ-ALoud — VIA BACK WINDOW

You pull yourself through the narrow window into a dusty, forgotten room. A clockmaker's study — desk, books, diagrams. No one has been here in years. Except for the young woman squatting on the desk, barefoot, with twigs in her hair. She tilts her head at you. “Well. You're not one of the little metal ones.”

NPCs AT A GLANCE

Moosfräulein Linde (*squatting on the desk, barefoot*) — Suspicious, curious, sizing them up. Can she use them?

LINDE

Up Close

No human sits like this. She squats on the desk like something perched on a rock, bare feet gripping the edge, dirt to the ankles. The dress looks grown rather than sewn, and there are wildflowers dying in her tangled hair. Her eyes are doing arithmetic on you.

Will Share Freely

- The “little metal ones” are dangerous
- The forest is dying because of the tower
- She has a document she knows is important somehow, but she can't read it — won't hand it over until she trusts the party

Will Share if She Trusts the Party

She wants the tower destroyed. The clockmaker tried to stop it and failed. The modrons won't stop — she's tried sabotage and they just repair it. Force alone won't work. Hands over the contract. She'll help if they act against the modrons.

Won't Share

Her true form, her coven, her backup plan (attack with the coven if players side with modrons), that she can't read.

Key Line

“The old clockmaker understood, eventually. The question is whether you're faster learners than he was.”

SECRETS

- Linde is a green hag using Illusory Appearance — DC 20 Investigation to see through, or physical touch reveals bark-like skin
- If players side with the modrons or refuse to act, Linde leaves through the window. She returns in Act III with her coven.
- **This is the branching point:** desired path (stop the modrons) vs. alternate path (protect the modrons from the hag coven)

ARTIFACT — THE CONTRACT

The full Contract of Planar Accord (physical prop — `props/documents/contract.tex`). Linde has it and knows it matters, but can't read it. Players must earn her

trust to get it. Art. VI §6.3 is the key: a failed activation sequence nullifies the contract entirely. Art. IV supplies the timing: the sequence commences at the striking of three — the party can plan their ascent around it.

CONNECTIONS

- **Interior:** Hidden door to the Clockhall
- **Exterior:** Window on the back of the tower

TRANSITION

Players now understand the full stakes. They must install the Gear (if they haven't already) to begin the activation sequence, then get to Cuckoo's Landing to stop it before 3 cycles complete.

CUCKOO'S LANDING

Act III • Boss Combat • Kuckucksuhrturn — Apex

READ-ALoud

The hatch swings open onto a narrow platform at the top of the tower. The floor beyond is a single massive bronze gear, its teeth meshing with the walls — still, and strangely clean, as though someone polishes it. Along the wall beside you stand two great doors, shut fast, taller than any door has a reason to be. The air riser you climbed beside runs through the wall and vanishes behind them, and from the seam between them leaks a thin line of cold, geometric light.

SECRETS

- The gear floor rotates 90° clockwise at initiative count 20 every round — creatures standing on it move with it; the platform, doors, rod, and flyers do not
- The fixed platform hugs the front wall: row A is a half-depth catwalk (squeezing), with full corner blocks at each end; the closed 10-ft doors conceal the planar aperture
- The cuckoo's cone fires in a fixed direction from center — rotation shifts who's in the blast zone
- Players can attempt to ride the cuckoo back into Mechanus when it retracts (DC 12 STR Athletics)

CONNECTIONS

- **Down:** Hatch at B2, ladder down beside the main air riser to the Bellows Chamber

VICTORY

Cuckoo destroyed before completing 3 cycles. Contract null and void (Art. VI §6.3). Aperture closes. Modrons immediately retreat. The broken cuckoo remains.

DEFEAT

Cuckoo completes 3 cycles. Planar anchor established. Connection to Mechanus permanent. Conformity spreads.

ALTERNATE PATH

If players sided with modrons, they defend the cuckoo against the hag coven + fey minions trying to break in.

ENCOUNTER

See next page.

ENCOUNTER — CUCKOO'S LANDING

Act III • Boss Combat • Deadly / 5 rounds (ON/OFF/ON/OFF/ON)

THE CUCKOO — CR 3 (CUSTOM OBJECTIVE)

AC	HP	Attack
16	~110	none — see below

No attack actions. Its entire turn is: emerge/retract + knockdown + modron wave + the Call. An objective to destroy, not a duelist — the waves and the battlefield are the threat.

Construct: Immune to poison and psychic damage; immune to the poisoned, charmed, frightened, exhaustion, paralyzed, and petrified conditions. No damage resistances — its HP and the battlefield are its defense.

Restrained on the rod: Attacks against it have advantage.

The Cuckoo's Call: 30 ft cone, DC 14 CON save. Fail: 3d8 thunder + poisoned until end of next turn (cancels restrained advantage). Save: half, no poisoned. Once per cycle.

Emergency Venting: Once, below half HP. 10 ft radius, DC 14 DEX save. Fail: 3d6 fire. Save: half. Melee punishment.

Defensive Lockdown (optional): AC +2 if going down too fast.

MODRON WAVES

Cycle	DPR	Enemies
1 (ON)	~26	4 monodrones — fly 30 ft; one-shot fodder (5 HP), but 2024 Gear attacks bite: real alpha-turn pressure
2 (ON)	~25	3 duodrones + 1 tridrone — ground only, rotate with the gear; multiattack makes them sticky
3 (ON)	~38	2 tridrones (ground) + 2 quadrones (fly) — Gears Launchers (320 ft) threaten the backline

Modron key stats (2024 MM):

	AC	HP	Attack
Monodrone	15	5	Gear +4, 6 (1d8+2) force — melee or 120 ft; fly 30
Duodrone	15	11	×2: Blade +3, 4 (1d6+1) force — melee or 30 ft
Tridrone	15	16	×3: Spear +3, 4 (1d6+1) force — melee or 120 ft
Quadrone	16	22	×4: Slam/Launcher +4, 4 (1d4+2) force — 320 ft; fly 30

READ-ALoud — FIRST EMERGENCE (ROUND 1)

The hour arrives, and the tower answers. The floor wrenches into motion — the whole gear grinding beneath your feet — and before it settles, the great doors detonate, slamming flat against the walls hard enough to ring the platform like a bell. Beyond the doorway, for a single held breath, you see the other side: gears the size of counties turning in a bright and endless nothing, meshing at impossible angles, all of them perfectly in step. Out of the light drives a bird of riveted brass the size of a carriage, thrust out on a telescoping rod, hinged wings flared wide, eyes like two blank dial faces. It shoots out and slams to a halt over the dead center of the floor, the rod still shuddering. Behind it, winged brass spheres pour through the doorway and fan out overhead. The bird's chest swells — and it calls: two colossal tones, high then low, like a cathedral clock striking inside your chest.

Pause after the slam for the door-slam DEX saves (and knockdown); the last line is the Call — roll the CON saves there. The party should reach the landing just before three — the sequence commences on the hour (Art. IV); each Call is one stroke.

ROUND STRUCTURE — THE MACHINE TURN

Everything the machine does happens on **initiative 20**, in this fixed order: **gear rotates 90° CW** → **cuckoo emerges/retracts (knockdown + door slam)** → **modron wave releases** → **the Call fires**. Only the PCs and the modron group roll initiative.

Rnd	Initiative 20
1 (ON)	Rotate. Doors slam (swing tiles). Emerges — knockdown (DC 14 DEX). Wave 1. The Call — first stroke of three.
2 (OFF)	Rotate. Retracts — knockdown. Hold-on window (DC 12 STR to ride in). Doors close.
3 (ON)	Rotate. Doors slam. Emerges — knockdown. Wave 2. The Call — second stroke.
4 (OFF)	Rotate. Retracts — knockdown. Hold-on window. Doors close.
5 (ON)	Rotate. Doors slam. Emerges — knockdown. Wave 3. The Call — third stroke completes the anchor. Last chance.

Rotation is perfectly predictable — the counterplay is reading the machine and positioning a round ahead, not winning initiative. Released waves act on the modron group's initiative, so the party gets a beat to react.

BATTLEFIELD

- **Floor:** single large gear (25 ft radius), rotates 90° CW at init 20
- **Platform (fixed, does NOT rotate):** row A is a half-depth catwalk — squeezing (half speed, disadvantage on attacks, attacks against you have advantage); corner blocks A/B 1–2 and 9–10 are full standing room. Hatch up from the Bellows Chamber at B2; air riser at B1.
- **Doors:** two 10-ft leaves; they slam outward 180° when the cuckoo deploys. Swing tiles (A2–A9, B2–B9, C3–C4, C7–C8): **DC 14 DEX; fail = 7 (2d6) bludgeoning + prone, save = half and stay standing**
- **Cone direction:** fixed from center — rotation shifts who's in the blast zone
- **Center hazard:** anyone at center when the cuckoo emerges → knockdown (DC 14 DEX)
- **Table procedure:** the platform sheet (doors closed) stays over row A all fight; the gear map rotates beneath it. ON cycles: set the rod piece on top — its head is the open doorway, its perch lands on the hub. OFF: lift it off.

RIDING INTO MECHANUS

- Grab on as it retracts: DC 12 STR (Athletics). The doorway is blocked while the cuckoo is extended — this is the only way through.
- On Mechanus: DC 14 WIS save at start of each turn or lose action (move/bonus fine)
- Ride back out next cycle. If the cuckoo dies while they're inside: door closes; the party must figure out retrieval.

TELEGRAPHING THE 3-CYCLE RULE

Primary: the contract, Art. VI §6.3 — players who read it know the termination clause — and Art. IV the timing: commencement at the striking of three, each cycle one stroke. Pendel can guide: “Activation at three o’clock. Precisely.” Backup (DM’s choice): a conflicted Pendel states it, Linde spells it out, or a modron announces “second emergence logged; one remains.” Deliver it by the end of cycle 1 if

nobody has connected it.

PENDEL DURING THE FIGHT

- **Befriended / pushed rogue:** sides with the party — stands clear but calls wave timings, states the 3-cycle rule, shouts where the Call is charging
- **Neutral:** freezes — torn, pleads with both sides, acts only at the very end (DM’s choice)
- **Antagonized:** assists the modron waves — directing them, never attacking PCs himself

END CONDITIONS

Victory: cuckoo at 0 HP before 3 full cycles. Contract null and void (§6.3). Aperture closes; modrons retreat immediately.

Defeat: the tower finishes striking three — 3 cycles complete. Planar anchor established. Conformity permanent.

Alternate path (improv — deliberately undesigned): party defends the cuckoo from Linde’s coven (3 green hags) + fey minions over 3 cycles. Coven spells are the real threat; action economy favors the party 7:3.

DM NOTES

- Initiative: PCs + one modron group roll; the cuckoo acts with the environment on 20
- The cuckoo is an objective/HP sponge — the modron waves are the real combat threat
- **Pace dial (7 players):** if the cuckoo isn’t near half HP by the end of cycle 2 (round 3), quietly drop one quadrone from wave 3; Defensive Lockdown (+2 AC) is the dial in the other direction
- The rotating floor constantly repositions everyone relative to the fixed cone; players who read the pattern can position a round ahead
- Frantic and mechanical — a machine to be dismantled, not a monster to be slain
- Map set: cuckoos_landing_map + overlay sheet + rod piece (print) / cuckoos_landing_guide (DM)

NPC — BÜRGERMEISTER GOTTFRIED GRÜBER

Reference • Act I • Freudenfeld

IDENTITY

Male, 60s. Inherited the Bürgermeister's seat from his father. Landed gentry — his family's wealth comes from owning land and collecting rents, not from trade or craft. He was a modestly successful businessman before taking over, but has never had to struggle for anything. Has a wife and several children.

APPEARANCE

Large and stout, overweight, an imposing physical presence. But the face saves him — bright, beaming, charismatic. He wears fine clothing and the large mayoral chain of office. Not a man you overlook when he's in a room.

MANNERISMS

Stays seated at his Stammtisch and calls people over to him. Claps you on the back, invites you to sit, makes you feel welcome immediately — but won't stand up for you. Loud baritone voice that fills the room; he likes to talk and it shows, though he knows how to get to the point when he needs to. His eyes are always working — scanning the room, noting who's there, observing more than he lets on. The jovial exterior masks a man who is paying quiet attention.

PSYCHOLOGY

Grüber cares about Freudenfeld, genuinely. But his identity is so entangled with the town's fortunes that he can't separate the two. He'd tell you it's about the people, and he might even believe it, but if the town's prosperity and his own well-being ever diverged, he wouldn't know which to choose.

His weaknesses: arrogance and a disregard for details. He's confident enough to think he understands a situation and careless enough to miss what would prove him wrong. When caught off guard or asked something uncomfort-

able — say, Eichenwald's concerns about the children — he laughs it off and changes the subject. He doesn't argue with the concern. He makes it disappear.

RELATIONSHIP TO THE TOWER

Grüber has never visited the Kuckucksuhrurm. He sent an agent who spoke briefly with Pendel and reported back. That was enough for him. He views the Tickwichtel as small mystical creatures, a good omen, and doesn't care to know more. Crime is down. The children behave. Why investigate what's working?

He believes the Uhrmacher was an eccentric recluse who drove himself mad and ruined his own tower. The reactivation, in Grüber's mind, is that mistake being corrected. The Tickwichtel are fixing what the clockmaker broke. This makes him especially dismissive of anyone raising doubts.

RELATIONSHIPS

Knows Frau Eichenwald but doesn't concern himself with her affairs. She has not brought her concerns to him directly. Familiar with Heinrich but not close — there's a class divide between the landowner and the woodcutter. Generally tolerated by the townsfolk; not a bad man or a bad politician, but people grumble about his arrogance when he's not in the room.

PLAYING GRÜBER

- Loud, warm, commanding. He runs the room without standing up.
- Gets to the point on business — the job, the pay, the directions.
- Deflects discomfort with laughter and subject changes, never confrontation.
- His eyes are always scanning. Players who notice may wonder if he's sharper than he seems.
- He genuinely believes the tower's effects are good for the town. He's not hiding anything — he just hasn't looked closely enough to see a problem.

NPC — FRAU EICHENWALD

Reference • Act I • Freudenfeld

IDENTITY

Margarethe Eichenwald, mid-40s, though everyone calls her Frau Eichenwald — as the children do. Unmarried. She moved to Freudenfeld as a young teacher when the position was available, and has been here ever since. The students are her life.

APPEARANCE

Proud and a bit gaunt. She carries herself with the straight-backed composure of someone accustomed to commanding a room of children, but in social settings outside the classroom she becomes more distant, less certain of her footing.

MANNERISMS

Speaks with a measured, intentional pace — precise but not clipped. Articulate. She chooses her words the way she'd expect her students to. When anxious or troubled, she turns inward, goes quiet, tries to reason her way through the problem. At the Gasthaus tonight she is sitting alone, staring at the table with an untouched drink, lost in thought. A player approaching might think she's just tired until they engage and realize she's been wrestling with something she can't solve.

PSYCHOLOGY

Eichenwald has stayed later at the Gasthaus than she normally would. She keeps a precise schedule — always has. Which is odd, given what's happening in the rest of the town. It's as though she's the one person resisting the ticking.

She is troubled because she can see what no one else seems to notice. Her students have lost their curiosity. Their imagination is fading. There are no more silly outbursts — and even though she always scolded them for it, she now realizes those disruptions were part of being a child, and their absence frightens her. The children's stories are

becoming bland. Their pictures are becoming prosaic. The very things that made her job difficult were the things that made it meaningful.

She has tried talking to parents, but they don't understand why she's concerned about "good behaviour." She respects Grüber's authority but is frustrated that the people who should be asking questions aren't. She respects the office more than the man.

FRITZ

She has noticed that Fritz is no longer attending class. She doesn't know where he's gone — just that he stopped showing up. This is a concrete worry sitting on top of her abstract unease.

THE UHRMACHER

She didn't grow up with the village stories — she learned them after moving here and always dismissed them as local legend. But now she's wondering if there's more to them. She believes the version where the Tickwichtel murdered the Uhrmacher. She deeply mistrusts them and blames them for what's happening to her students — "poisoning" the children.

PLAYING EICHENWALD

- Measured, articulate, composed on the surface. Visibly troubled underneath.
- She won't volunteer her concerns to strangers unprompted — but if the players approach her and she senses good intentions, she is relieved to finally talk about it.
- She doesn't have answers. She has the right instincts and the wrong audience.
- If the players mention heading to the tower, she asks them to be careful — the Uhrmacher may have learned something dangerous.
- She can mention Fritz's absence, giving the party an early thread to the Winding Room.

NPC — HEINRICH

Reference • Act I • Freudenfeld

IDENTITY

Late 60s. Woodcutter his entire life, still working though he's slowed down in his later years. Born and raised in Freudenfeld, never left. Had a wife who died years ago and a daughter who left the village long ago — he misses her but is happy she's living her own life. He occasionally took on apprentices, but it's been many years since the last one. The Gasthaus is his main social outlet.

APPEARANCE

Sinewy but tough — a body shaped by decades of physical labour in the Tiefenwald. Hunched from years of chopping, but with the kindest old smile. The sort of face that makes strangers trust him immediately.

MANNERISMS

Always chatty. Loves to tell a story, loves gossip, but doesn't open up about his own feelings. Speaks with a storyteller's cadence and a twinkle in his eye. Gesticulates with wide sweeping gestures when he gets into a tale. Drinks while he talks — the pipe and the tankard are part of the performance.

THE TICKWICHTEL ENCOUNTER

When Heinrich was seven, around the time the Uhrmacher first built the tower, he saw a Tickwichtel in the woods. A small clicking creature that barely noticed him. Nothing actually happened — it didn't interact with him, just went about its business — but it was a deeply formative experience for a young boy. As the tower's effects escalated and then came to a mysterious end, he knew the Tickwichtel was somehow involved.

He has told the story a hundred times since. He views himself as an expert. The details aren't all right anymore: he believes the Tickwichtel were giving magical powers to the Uhrmacher, and that they could control time itself. His version of events is wrong in the specifics but captures

something emotionally true — the Tickwichtel were involved, and time and precision are at the heart of it. He built a folklore around the gaps in his understanding.

PSYCHOLOGY

Heinrich doesn't quite know what to make of the tower reactivating. He's excited — he's a bit of a celebrity again, and people are paying attention to his old stories for the first time in years. But he also remembers a deep sense of unease from childhood, that things "weren't right," and that something tragic happened. He believes the Uhrmacher's experiments went too far, and that the clockmaker accidentally froze himself in time when the ticking stopped. He carries both joy and dread about the Tickwichtel simultaneously. The nostalgia is genuine. The unease is genuine. He hasn't reconciled them.

RELATIONSHIPS

No special relationship with Grüber or Eichenwald. The village folk listen to his stories — some think he's crazy, some are intrigued. He doesn't know anything about Fritz's disappearance.

PLAYING HEINRICH

- Warm, rambling, performative. A natural storyteller who holds court near the Kachelofen.
- The Tickwichtel story is his showpiece — he'll tell it to anyone who sits down. Wide gestures, twinkle in the eye, practised cadence.
- His information is colourful but unreliable. The emotional truth is there; the facts are not.
- If asked, he'd confidently offer to take the party into the woods in the morning to show them where he saw the creature — unclear how well he actually remembers the spot.
- He provides the folkloric lens on the tower: charming, wondrous, but with something dark underneath that he can feel but can't articulate.

NPC — PENDEL

Reference • Act II • Kuckucksuhrturn

IDENTITY

Quadrone. The highest-ranking modron at the tower, responsible for executing the Contract of Planar Accord on site. Answers to higher modrons in Mechanus, but here he is the authority. He worked alongside the Uhrmacher during the tower's original construction and operation. When the Uhrmacher disappeared and the work stopped, Pendel stayed. He sat motionless in the dormant tower for decades, alone, with no orders and no hierarchy — just waiting.

APPEARANCE

Standard quadrone form: a bronze and brass cube with recessed eyes, two short legs, two arms, and a pair of fan-like mechanical wings. His defining features are a hairline crack in one side of his body and a tiny weed growing from it — not recent. The plant has been growing in him for years, possibly decades, a physical manifestation of the forest slowly getting into him while he sat motionless.

MANNERISMS

Moves more frenetically than the other modrons. His voice is not quite monotone anymore — there are inflections where there shouldn't be. He hedges: "Well, that's exactly right, isn't it?" He rapidly shifts focus between tasks. He is very quick to agree with suggestions. A modron who hedges and people-pleases is deeply wrong by modron standards — they should be decisive, precise, binary. Pendel is none of those things.

PSYCHOLOGY

Pendel spent decades in isolation from Mechanus, sitting in silence in the Uhrmacher's tower. During that time, the crack formed. The weed started growing. He began noticing things — seasons changing, the forest growing outside, the craftsmanship of the tower around him. He doesn't have the word for it, but he loves the tower. The Uhrmacher was a master whose work inspired even a modron.

When orders finally came to reactivate the contract, it hit him like a wave. Too much, too fast — the full weight of the hierarchy snapping back into place after decades of nothing. He went into a frenzy. By the time the party arrives, he is still overwhelmed. Lesser-ranking modrons

fill the tower, looking to him for direction, and he is barely holding it together. He is technically in charge but privately reeling.

He doesn't know why the Uhrmacher stopped the work. He doesn't know it was a deliberate choice. He thinks the clockmaker simply disappeared. He hasn't thought about the consequences of the activation — he's just following orders because that's what modrons do.

THE ROGUE ARC

Pendel doesn't know he's acting strangely. He hasn't gotten there on his own. But the players can be the catalyst.

The crack opens in stages. First, the players must engage with his oddities — ask about the name he chose, point out the weed, notice his hesitations. These questions make him aware of himself. Only then can they make him understand what the activation means. You can't skip to "this is bad" without first establishing "you're not like the others."

The deepest cut: telling Pendel that the Uhrmacher shut the tower down on purpose. That the man he admired didn't abandon the work by accident — he rejected it. Pendel has been faithfully waiting to resume something his partner deliberately ended.

If he goes fully rogue, Pendel will no longer work on executing the contract. What he does beyond that depends on the roleplaying context — he could actively help the party, or simply step aside. What happens to a rogue modron cut off from Mechanus permanently is an unresolved question for him, not something he has an answer to.

PLAYING PENDEL

- Not quite monotone. Inflections slip in. He hedges, agrees too quickly, shifts between tasks frenetically.
- He is trying to be the authority he's supposed to be. He is not succeeding.
- His love for the tower comes through in how he talks about the mechanism, the craftsmanship. He doesn't recognise it as love.
- The weed and the name are the entry points. Players who engage with these can start cracking him open.
- The Uhrmacher revelation — that the clockmaker chose to stop — is the deepest lever. Use it when the moment is right.
- Don't rush the arc. Let the players drive it.

NPC — FRITZ

Reference • Act II • Kuckucksuhrturn — Below

IDENTITY

Eleven years old. From Freudenfeld. His mother raised him alone — his father left when he was little and is no longer in his life. Born with a congenital leg condition; he's never known anything different. He walked with a crude brace — wood and leather, village craftsmanship, something his mother or the local carpenter fashioned for him. He's been living in the tower's basement for a few days, drawn by the ticking.

APPEARANCE

Scrappy, thin, dirty from living rough. Messy dark hair, bright defiant eyes. Patched-up peasant clothes that are too big for him. A wild passion behind his eyes and a look like he's hiding something — not lying, but waiting for mutual respect before he opens up. His leg brace lies discarded on the floor near his bedroll.

THE LEG

The tower's ticking has been “regulating” his leg — he doesn't understand why, but it works now. For the first time in his life. He didn't lose something and get it back — he gained something he never had. The discarded brace near the bedroll tells the whole story before the players even meet him. He believes the tower is responsible and doesn't think the ticking will stop. If he thought it would, he'd be afraid.

THE JOURNAL

Fritz found the old clockmaker's journal in the works and has tried to read it — but he can't read well, and has only understood pieces. The warnings went over his head. He'll show it (or hand it over) once treated with respect — a roleplay reward, not a floor pickup.

PSYCHOLOGY

Fritz is fiercely independent, deeply creative, a lover of books, quick to engage and challenge, a deep thinker, and a lover of adventure. The tower has given the most adventurous kid in the village working legs for the first time, and now he's camped out in an underground winding room living out the adventure he's always dreamed of. He's not hiding. He's thriving.

He snuck into the basement and found a large brass winding key on the floor near the golem. He tried it in the keyhole on the golem's back, and a giant came to life. It startled him at first, then thrilled him. He's been avoiding the modrons — they don't know he's here.

He doesn't feel particularly guilty about disappearing from home. He's eleven. But if someone spelled out clearly what his mother is going through, it would register.

THE DILEMMA

Fritz is the emotional heart of the adventure's moral question. Stopping the tower means his leg stops working. If the players try to lie about this, sugar-coat it, or talk around it, he'll resist. If they tell him the clear truth — both what will happen to the town and what will happen to him — he can take it. An eleven-year-old being braver about this than most of the adults in the story.

The key to winning Fritz over is honesty and respect. Treat him as an equal with a say in what happens, rather than telling him what to do. Adults giving orders is the fastest way to make him dig in.

RELATIONSHIPS

His mother is worried and doesn't know where he is. Frau Eichenwald has noticed he's no longer attending class — she doesn't know where he's gone either. He has no relationship with the other NPCs in the tower; the modrons don't know he exists.

PLAYING FRITZ

- When the party enters the Winding Room, Fritz sends the golem to chase them away and hides. He stays silent until found.
- When found: defiance first. Not fear, not negotiation. Defiance.
- He opens up to players who talk to him straight, kneel down, treat him as a person with agency. He shuts down if patronised or ordered around.
- The brace on the floor is the first thing to notice. Let the players see it and figure out what it means before they meet him.
- The winding key is his power — taking it from him is possible but would feel like a betrayal. Earning his trust is the right path.
- Don't shortcut the moral weight. Let the players sit with the fact that saving the village costs this kid his legs.

NPC — MOOSFRÄULEIN LINDE

Reference • Act II / III • Kuckucksuhrturn — Study

IDENTITY

Green hag, several hundred years old. Medium-aged for a fey creature. Old enough that the tower sixty years ago is a recent memory, not ancient history. She watched the Uhrmacher build it, watched the effects on the forest, watched it go dormant. Now it's happening again. She is one of three sisters — a coven. Elke and Briar are biding their time in the deep forest. Linde is acting on her own initiative but has kept them informed.

APPEARANCE — DISGUISED

A quirky young woman with an unmistakably wild quality. Tangled hair with twigs and wildflowers. A dress that looks grown rather than sewn. Barefoot, dirt on her feet. Sharp, curious eyes. When the party finds her, she is squatting on the desk — ignoring the chair entirely. No human sits like that. Everything about her posture says *animal perched on a rock*, not *woman sitting in a study*.

APPEARANCE — TRUE FORM

An ancient creature of the deep forest. Rough bark for skin, draped in living moss and lichen. Long tangled hair of hanging moss and dead leaves. Eyes glowing faintly green from deep sockets. Fingers like twisted roots. Small mushrooms and ferns sprouting from her shoulders. Unsettling but not monstrous — ancient and wild rather than evil.

MANNERISMS

In disguise: lighter, more playful, performing the curious young woman. But the cracks show. She squats instead of sitting. She can't read and tries to hide it. She watches the players the way a predator watches movement. If she loses her temper — particularly if someone suggests the modrons are here to help — the disguise slips. A flash of bark-skin, her voice dropping into something older and rougher. The primal hag showing through.

In true form: guttural, direct, no performance. Primal. A creature who howls at the full moon, brews potions that cause visions, hunts forest animals. Circle of life.

She fears sharp metal objects. Cold, precise, manufactured things — the antithesis of everything she is.

PSYCHOLOGY

Linde is a wild spirit in love with the forest. She does not care about Freudenfeld or its people. If the tower's effects were limited to the village and didn't touch the Tiefenwald, she wouldn't lift a finger. She is not an ally — she is a co-belligerent. Her interests align with the party's right

now, but her motivations are entirely her own.

She remembers what the forest was like before the tower. Wild and wonderful. Then the biome started regulating: animals walking in lines, crooked paths growing straight, leaves falling all at the same time, birds singing in clean arpeggios and simple rhythms, light rain twice a week on Tuesday and Thursday afternoons. Her potions and magic losing potency. It's not abstract for her. It's existential.

When the tower went dormant, the forest largely recovered. But the river still runs in a perfectly straight line near the tower — a permanent scar from the original activation. Now the small effects are creeping back.

THE SABOTAGE

Linde has already been fighting back. She's been causing vines, moss, and mushrooms to grow into the tower's gears. The players may notice modrons cleaning these out when they first arrive at the Clockhall. She's learned through experience that brute force doesn't work — the modrons just repair the damage and keep coming. She knows the contract is the key somehow, but she can't read it. She wants to destroy the tower entirely if possible.

WHAT SHE OFFERS

The main thing she provides is the contract itself — she has it and knows it's important, but can't interpret it. She won't hand it over until she trusts the party. Beyond the contract, she can help the players understand that the modrons won't stop. They keep coming back. Force won't work. The players need to find a way to convince them, or find a legal mechanism to end the arrangement.

PLAYING LINDE

- Suspicious and curious when the party arrives. She's sizing them up — can she use them?
- The disguise is a performance, but the wildness is real. Squatting on furniture, bare feet, the way she watches people — something feral that observant players should catch.
- She won't hand over the contract freely. Players must earn her trust. When she does give it up, she frames it to hide her illiteracy: "Tell me what you make of this."
- If players suggest the modrons are helpful, she gets upset. The disguise cracks — bark-skin, rough voice. Don't let this go unnoticed.
- If players refuse to act or side with the modrons, she leaves through the window. She returns in Act III with Elke and Briar.
- She is not good. She is not evil. She is wild, and the tower is killing what she loves.

NPC — WILHELM ZEIGER, THE UHRMACHER

Reference • Background • Deceased

IDENTITY

The clockmaker who built the Kuckucksuhrturn. He vanished in 1742; the present is 1804 — gone some sixty years when the adventure begins. Never married, lived alone. Left no family. His real name is largely forgotten — the village knows him simply as the Uhrmacher.

THE MAN

Wilhelm Zeiger was a kind soul, intensely dedicated to his craft. Soft-spoken, always gentle when he interacted with people, but fundamentally solitary. He became well known regionally and was widely considered a master clockmaker at a young age. His workshop evolved over time — he wanted more room and more isolation, and moved deeper into the Tiefenwald. The workshop ultimately became the tower, driven by two needs: his pursuit of perfect time-keeping, and the practical need for a reference clock.

APPEARANCE

[TBD — to be developed with portrait prompt]

THE TOWER

The Kuckucksuhrturn grew organically from practical need, not a grand plan. It kept getting taller, more ambitious, as his pursuit of precision demanded it. Through his professional network he became acquainted with a planar traveller, who put him in contact with an agent from Mechanus. A clockmaker who wanted perfect time, meeting beings from a plane of perfect order. It must have seemed like a dream. One thing led to another, and the Contract of Planar Accord was signed.

THE REALISATION

It was gradual. He noticed changes in the forest first — curious. Then similar patterns in the town — concerning. His writings track the arc: early entries are optimistic, proud of the tower's precision, excited about the Gear. Later entries grow concerned, then desperate. He was more worried about the effect on the town than any effect on himself personally, which he may not have noticed.

There is a tragic irony here: the most precise man in the region might not have recognised precision being imposed on him. How would he tell the difference?

THE END

When he decided to act, he removed the Cross-Planar Regulation Gear himself and re-packed it in its original modron shipping crate in the bellows chamber. Then he disappeared. He left on his own terms. What he did with the

rest of his life is unknown.

Nobody knows the truth of his departure. The tower went silent. The Tickwichtel stopped appearing. The forest slowly recovered. Freudenfeld was left with a dormant tower in the woods and a legend that grew stranger with every generation.

THE LEGENDS OF THE UHRMACHER

The Uhrmacher has achieved mythical status in Freudenfeld. Everyone heard stories growing up, and everyone believes something a little different. The main flavours:

The Madman

His clock brought blessings to the town, but he was an eccentric recluse who drove himself mad and ended up ruining his own tower in the process. This is why Grüber is optimistic about the Tickwichtel — they're putting right what the clockmaker broke. (*Wrong — the "ruin" was deliberate, and the "blessings" were the early stages of conformity.*)

Frozen in Time

His experiments went too far and he accidentally froze himself in time when the ticking stopped. He's still in there somewhere, suspended. (*Heinrich's version. Wrong, but captures that something unnatural happened with time.*)

Murdered by the Tickwichtel

The Tickwichtel were jealous of his clock and killed him. Eichenwald's version — she deeply mistrusts the Tickwichtel and blames them for "poisoning" her students. (*Wrong, but the Tickwichtel are the reason he had to flee.*)

The Evil Miser

He was a mean-spirited miser who created the Tickwichtel to torment the town, like a reverse Saint Nicholas. (*The opposite of who he was. The kind of story that grows when people can't explain something.*)

The Guardian

He was a protector who fought off the Tickwichtel when they came to torment the town. (*The closest to the truth — he did fight against what the modrons were doing to protect Freudenfeld. Just gets the details backward about who summoned whom.*)

PLAYING THE LEGEND

- Every NPC has a slightly different take on the Uhrmacher, and none of them are fully right.
- The journal entries are the players' window into the real man. The contrast between the legend and the quiet, kind voice in the journals should be striking.
- The truth is simpler and sadder than any of the legends: a good man made a deal he didn't fully understand, recognised the harm too late, and gave up everything to undo it.

GLOSSARY & PRONUNCIATION GUIDE

Reference • All Acts • —

PLACES

Freudenfeld (*FROY-den-felt*) — “Field of joy.” The village where the adventure begins.

Tiefenwald (*TEE-fen-vahlt*) — “Deep forest.” The woods surrounding the tower.

Kuckucksuhrturn (*KOO-kooks-oor-toorm*) — “Cuckoo clock tower.” The tower itself.

Gasthaus (*GAHST-house*) — Inn or tavern. The Act I meeting place.

Stammtisch (*SHTAHM-tish*) — “Regulars’ table.” The Bürgermeister’s usual seat.

PEOPLE

Bürgermeister (*BUR-ger-my-ster*) — Mayor. Gottfried Grüber’s title.

Gottfried Grüber (*GOT-freed GROO-ber*) — The Bürgermeister of Freudenfeld.

Frau Eichenwald (*frow EYE-khen-vahlt*) — “Mrs. Oak-forest.” The schoolteacher.

Heinrich (*HINE-rikh*) — The old woodcutter. No surname.

Wilhelm Zeiger (*VIL-helm TSAI-ger*) — “Pointer/hand (of a clock).” The Uhrmacher’s full name.

Uhrmacher (*OOR-mahkh-er*) — “Clockmaker.” What everyone calls him. Long dead.

Fritz — The boy living in the tower. No surname.

Pendel (*PEN-del*) — “Pendulum.” The quadrone overseer. Chose his own name.

Linde (*LIN-deh*) — “Linden tree.” The lead Moosfräulein.

Moosfräulein (*MOHS-froy-line*) — “Moss maiden.” What the hags call themselves. Folklore term: *Moosweibchen* (*MOHS-vybe-khen*).

Elke (*EL-keh*) — Second moss woman. Appears only in alternate path (Act III).

Briar — Third moss woman. Appears only in alternate path (Act III).

THINGS

Tickwichtel (*TICK-vikh-tel*) — What the townsfolk call the modrons. Folksy, affectionate. From *Wichtel* (small woodsprite) + *tick* (clockwork sound).

Kachelofen (*KAKH-el-oh-fen*) — Ceramic tile stove. Traditional Black Forest heating.

Bekanntmachung (*beh-KAHNT-mahkh-oong*) — Public notice. The pest control advertisement.

CONCEPTS

Contract of Planar Accord — The binding agreement between the Uhrmacher and the modrons of Mechanus. Physical prop.

Art. VI §6.3 — The critical contract clause: a failed activation sequence nullifies the entire contract. The party’s path to victory.

Activation Sequence — The process of establishing the planar anchor. Three cuckoo cycles, commencing at the striking of three (Art. IV) — each Call is one stroke of the hour. Must be started *then stopped* to trigger §6.3.

Cross-Planar Regulation Gear — The Mechanus gear that connects the tower to the plane of law. Players must install it to begin the sequence.

Planar Aperture — The portal at the tower’s apex, where the cuckoo emerges from Mechanus.

Mechanus — The modrons’ home plane. Pure law and order. Geometric, cold, mechanical.